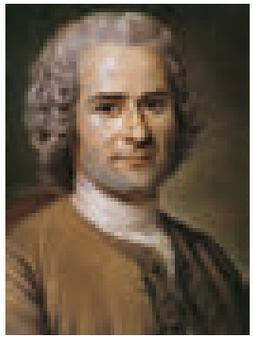
The middle class and the peasants together formed the Third Estate. The bourgeoisie (the capitalist class) were the privileged few but the bulk of the Third Estate was constituted by the representatives of peasants. The peasants paid taxes to the state such as *taille* (land tax), *gabelle* (salt tax), etc., and provided free labour (*corvee)* for the construction of public roads. Burdened by the demands of the state, nobility and clergy, the peasants were in despair at the prospect of dying of starvation.

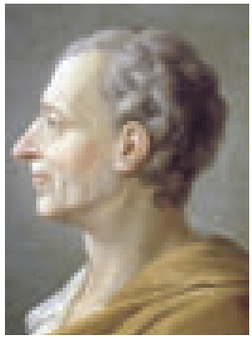
Inspiration from French Philosophers


Voltaire

There were many notable thinkers and writers in France in the eighteenth century. The most famous writer of the time on rationalistic and scientific subjects was Voltaire (1694-1778). When imprisoned and banished, he had to live at Ferney near Geneva. Voltaire, Montesquieu (1689-1755) and Rousseau criticized the then existing conditions in France. Voltaire, was a prolific writer and activist, and was vehement in his criticism of the Church. His most famous work was *Candide*. His famous quote was: "those who can make you believe absurdities can make you commit atrocities." He is said to have once exclaimed, "I disapprove of what you say, but I will defend to the death your right to say it."


Rousseau

Another great writer, a contemporary of Voltaire, but younger than him, was Jean Jacques Rousseau (1712-78). His political theory set the minds of many afire with new ideas and new resolves. His ideas played an important part in preparing the people of France for the great revolution. He famously said in his book *Social Contract*, "Man is born free, but is everywhere in chains." He argued that the laws are binding only when they are supported by the general will of the people.


Montesquieu

Montesquieu (1689-1755), who wrote *The Persian Letters* and *The Spirit of the Laws*, also defended liberty. He put forward the theory of separation of powers: The liberty of the individual would be best protected only in a government where the powers of its three organs, viz., legislature, executive and judiciary were separate. It would put in place the necessary checks and balances to prevent any one organ from assuming more power to itself.

An Encyclopaedia also came out in Paris about this time and this was full of articles by Diderot and Jean d'Alembert. These philosophers and thinkers, opposed to religious intolerance and political and social privileges, succeeded in provoking large numbers of ordinary people to think and act.

American War of Independence

The American Revolution that broke out in 1776 and ended with the establishment of the American Republic inspired the French Revolution and provided them with a model. The French participation in the American War of Independence supporting the American cause against the British directly affected the French Revolution in two ways: one, it cost the French treasury heavily and the other, the French like Lafayette who participated in the American War of Independence came back with democratic ideals and played an active role in the French Revolution.

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